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From war ally to struggling evacuee

Alleged Guard shooter was in elite Afghan unit, then foundered in U.S.

BY SUSANNAH GEORGE, ANTONIO OLIVO, WARREN P. STROBEL AND JEREMY ROEBUCK

Rahmanullah Lakanwal's squad was usually the first to venture out on counterterrorism reconnaissance missions in Afghanistan's southern provinces, often at night, to confirm the location of high-level Taliban commanders and other targets before the rest of the CIA-backed unit swooped in to capture or kill. Lakanwal joined Unit 03, also known as the Kandahar Strike Force, sometime around 2011 and quickly gained a reputation as a stellar soldier, working with U.S. forces in one of the most dangerous parts of Afghanistan, according to a former U.S. intelligence officer who served in Afghanistan and has knowledge of the CIA-trained "Zero Units."

As part of Unit 03, an elite Afghan counterterrorism team working in parallel with U.S. special operators and spies, Lakanwal had to go through multiple layers of vetting: to see if he was good at following orders, reliable during what were often chaotic firefights and loyal to the U.S. advisers who joined them on the missions, said the former officer, who spoke on the condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to speak about the still-active investigation. This vetting process occurred frequently — a constant reassessing, this person and another former U.S. official said.

SEE ZERO UNITS ON A12

Cheers for Pope Leo in Lebanon



MOHAMMED YASSIN/REUTERS

Waving yellow and white Vatican flags, a crowd in Bkerké, Lebanon, greets Pope Leo XIV as he arrives Monday for an event focused on young people. The pope's visit to Lebanon is inspiring fresh hope for peace. **Story, A14**

Fallout of boat strike mounts

LAWMAKERS CALL FOR ACCOUNTABILITY

White House says officer, not Hegseth, directed hit

BY NOAH ROBERTSON AND TARA COPP

Officials in Congress and the Pentagon said Monday they are increasingly concerned that the Trump administration intends to scapegoat the military officer who directed U.S. forces to kill two survivors of a targeted strike on suspected drug smugglers in Latin America, as lawmakers made initial moves to investigate whether the attack constituted a war crime.

The Washington Post reported exclusively Friday that Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth gave a spoken order to kill the entire crew of a vessel thought to be ferrying narcotics in the Caribbean Sea, the first of nearly 20 such strikes directed by the administration since early September.

When two survivors were detected, the military commander overseeing the operation, Adm. Frank M. Bradley, directed another strike to comply with Hegseth's order that no one be left alive, people with direct knowledge of the matter told The Post. The Trump administration has said 11 people were killed as a result of the operation.

Karoline Leavitt, the White House press secretary, acknowledged Monday that Hegseth had authorized Bradley to conduct the strikes on Sept. 2. Bradley, she added, "worked well within his authority and the law, directing

SEE STRIKE ON A5

Behind super PAC boom, a less-known legal case

BY BETH REINHARD

Six days after the Supreme Court's decision in *Citizens United v. Federal Election Commission*, President Barack Obama broke from the norms of polite deference and rebuked the justices sitting before him in the front row during his 2010 State of the Union speech.

Over the next 15 years, the left increasingly demonized *Citizens United* for all that ails American politics. Last year, as Elon Musk spent \$294 million to return

Donald Trump to the White House and elect other Republicans, Sen. Bernie Sanders (I-Vermont) repeatedly condemned the "disastrous" ruling.

But the intense focus on *Citizens United* has obscured a less-recognized campaign finance case, one that never made it to the Supreme Court. *SpeechNow.org v. FEC* actually paved the way for the super PACs frequently used by billionaires like Musk for election-year spending sprees.

While *Citizens United* abol-

ished the ban on independent expenditures by corporations and unions, *SpeechNow* went one step further. It erased limits on contributions to political committees that make independent expenditures and don't give money directly to candidates or parties. These entities took on the catchier name of super PACs.

The liberal outcry over that Supreme Court decision drowned out the *SpeechNow* opinion when it landed just two months later. And though *SpeechNow* was also expected to

reach the Supreme Court, then-Attorney General Eric H. Holder Jr. did not pursue a review of the 2010 decision by the U.S. Court of Appeals for the District of Columbia Circuit, predicting at the time that it "will affect only a small subset of federally regulated contributions."

He was mistaken. In the 2008 cycle, before super PACs, political nonprofits and other groups spent \$140 million on independent expenditures. By 2012, independent expenditures in federal

SEE CASE ON A10

Removal of Pride crosswalks in Md. city sparks a backlash

BY JOE HEIM

SALISBURY, MD. — It was a little over an hour into the city council meeting when tensions finally boiled over.

Randy Taylor, the mayor of this community of about 33,000 on Maryland's Eastern Shore, had had enough.

"Stop it with all the criticisms. I'm on your team," Taylor said, whacking the table in front of him as he glared at the council members. "I've been here my whole life and I'm sick of it. You guys piling up on me like you're superior. I don't get it. Like I'm this bigot and racist or whatever. I'm sick of it. I'm not that person."

Council member Michele Gregory fired back moments later: "Mr. Mayor, if you don't want to be called a bigot, don't do bigoted things."

The dustup last month had its roots in a number of contentious

issues, including disagreements over approaches to affordable housing and handicapped access. But it was a decision Taylor made earlier this year and set in motion three days before the meeting that ignited the exchange.

In May, Taylor said Salisbury would remove its only rainbow crosswalks from a downtown intersection. Painted to reflect LG-BTQ+ inclusion in 2018, they were the first of their kind in Maryland.

"Our City is home to a diverse and vibrant community, and we want our public spaces to be welcoming to all," Taylor, who was elected in 2023, said in a statement announcing the decision. The city had a responsibility, he continued, "to ensure that government property remains neutral and does not promote any particular movement or cause."

SEE SALISBURY ON A6



PETER W. STEVENSON/THE WASHINGTON POST

Dreaming of a light Christmas

Lego portraits of Presidents George Washington and Donald Trump flank the Christmas tree in the White House's Green Room, where construction meant pared-back decorating. **Story, B1**

GOP faces familiar dilemma on Obamacare

BY DAN DIAMOND, RILEY BEGGIN AND JACOB BOGAGE

Republican leaders have found themselves in a familiar place: pledging to make major changes to the Affordable Care Act, citing rising health care costs and a looming deadline — but far from agreeing on how to do it.

The White House last week privately floated a framework to extend billions of dollars in ACA subsidies that are set to expire Dec. 31, accompanied by other changes to the health care law long sought by conservatives. But a planned announcement was quickly nixed amid a rebellion from congressional Republicans who balked at the White House's ideas and process, and it is unclear when — or whether — President Donald Trump will endorse a specific legislative path. Several Senate Republicans have offered their own proposals, though it is not clear whether they can achieve sufficient support to pass the chamber.

Republicans promised a mid-December vote on how to proceed on the expiring subsidies, in exchange for support from some Democrats for ending the government shutdown in November. Democrats have argued that the

SEE GOP ON A8

Once-banned Irish language sees a resurgence in Belfast — Unionist areas included

BY STEVE HENDRIX AND AMANDA FERGUSON

BELFAST — In a colorful modular building monitored by CCTV cameras, Ciara Moore sat in front of seven squirming 4-year-olds and did something that some people here in the capital of Northern Ireland — maybe the ones who occasionally throw raw eggs over

the two locked security fences — consider an act of insurgency: She put a tiny bunny puppet on her index finger and said the word "coinín."

That's Irish for rabbit, which her mixed group of Protestant and Catholic preschoolers dutifully repeated back to her. They did the same for the Gaeilge (Irish) words for "dog," "blue," "yellow" and

"gingerbread man" ("fear sinséir").

The lessons are rudimentary, but that they are happening in Belfast — especially in this heavily Unionist neighborhood where Union Jacks are more likely to be seen than Irish flags — is remarkable and profound.

Moore is a teacher and the principal of Scoil na Seolta

(School of Sails), which opened last year as the first all-Irish-language preschool and primary school in East Belfast, where many painted walls still pay homage to the armed Unionist paramilitaries of the country's decades-long sectarian conflict.

Built on the site of a closed industrial drill-bit factory, the school is part of a resurgence of

Irish language spreading across Northern Ireland, where for centuries the ancient Celtic tongue had been driven out of public use by law, custom and hostility.

Gaeilge's growing popularity — even among Protestant parents who have signed up enough children to double the size of Moore's class next year — marks a stark

SEE BELFAST ON A15

IN THE NEWS

An illegal appointment A federal appeals court ruled that the Trump administration's actions to keep Alina Habba as the top prosecutor in New Jersey were unlawful. **A4**

'Operation Midway Blitz' Business has plummeted in Chicago's Little Village, a heavily Latino commercial district. **A3**

THE NATION **A study** in a small number of patients shows a promising path toward a cure for HIV. **A2** **The high court** appears skeptical of efforts to hold internet providers liable for piracy. **A4**

THE WORLD **A new report** finds that China is expanding its use of AI for surveillance and censorship. **A16** **President Donald Trump** said he would pardon a convicted Honduran leader. **A17**

THE ECONOMY **New regulations** in some states aim to prevent hiring discrimination by AI and other automated systems. **A19** **Watching old TV** shows in clips, and sharing the experience with others, is bringing people a surprising amount of joy. **A19**

STYLE **Olivia Nuzzi's** memoir is light on gossip and on reckoning. **B1**

SPORTS **Treyton Burks's** one-handed catch on Sunday night is the kind of play the Commanders can cling to for hope, Barry Svrluga writes. **B7**

THE REGION **Janeese Lewis George**, a D.C. Council member since 2021, announced her candidacy for next year's mayoral race. **B13** **Va. Gov.-elect** Abigail Spanberger (D) is going to act fast on a pragmatic agenda but will face budget challenges. **B13**

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